Practice Letter: Russia's hybrid war threat

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Practice Letter

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Russia's hybrid warfare threat and why companies should care

This is the latest in a series of periodic letters to clients in which Eurasia Group's practices present their views on forthcoming political and macro developments for their regions or sectors.

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Dear clients,

In recent client and student engagements, I've often fielded questions about Russia's hybrid warfare capabilities, the threat they pose to European governments and NATO, and whether Moscow is likely to replicate these tactics elsewhere. I've received fewer questions about how hybrid warfare could affect companies and critical industries, making this a good opportunity to lay out several observations on the issue, drawn mainly from my three decades in the US intelligence community and my more recent experience as a senior executive in the defense sector—a frequent target of Russian hybrid operations.

How Russia wages hybrid warfare

First, some context. Recognizing Russia's weakness relative to the West's conventional military advantage, President Vladimir Putin embarked on an effort more than a decade ago to expand Russia's asymmetric weapons arsenal and hybrid warfighting capabilities. On the weapons side, Putin prioritized several types of hypersonic missiles to challenge NATO's air defenses, as well as undersea stealth platforms and nuclear-powered autonomous underwater drones designed to devastate coastal cities and naval facilities. Press reports indicate that Russia also began developing a space-based anti-satellite weapon with a nuclear capability for low Earth orbit. Taken together, these efforts aimed to level the playing field against the West should it consider engaging Russia militarily.

At the same time, Putin built and deployed an extensive set of hybrid capabilities that allowed Russia to threaten Western interests while preserving plausible deniability and avoiding the type of offensive action that could trigger an all-out war with NATO. These tactics, which Russia now uses routinely against its European neighbors, include sabotage, targeted assassinations, airspace violations, satellite jamming, attacks on critical undersea infrastructure, cyberattacks, and election interference.

The intelligence services driving the effort

As widely documented, Putin has tasked Russia's three main intelligence services with conducting the country's hybrid warfare campaign in ways that obscure Moscow's role: the Foreign Intelligence Service (SVR), Russia's main civilian foreign intelligence agency; the Main Intelligence Directorate (GRU),

Russia's military intelligence agency; and the Federal Security Service (FSB), Russia's main domestic security agency, which has also assumed some foreign intelligence responsibilities.

Some of Russia's more publicized recent external operations include:

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Repeated incursions into the airspace of NATO countries by fighter aircraft and drones.
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The placement of explosive packages on commercial aircraft and reported drone activity near European airports. In one especially brazen incident last month, the German government accused the GRU of launching drones near Leipzig airport, including one that reportedly targeted a parked Ukrainian cargo aircraft.
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Numerous alleged plots against senior executives at major defense companies supplying weapons to Ukraine. One case involved a plan to assassinate the CEO of a major German arms manufacturer, alongside other suspected plots targeting arms defense executives in Germany and Sweden.
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Reported involvement in the cutting of undersea telecommunications and energy cables in the Baltic Sea.
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Offensive cyber operations across Europe, including in Norway and Poland.

These activities have gained momentum in recent years. With Russia's defense spending set to rise sharply in 2027—by more than 25% year-on-year—I assume that more funding will flow to this part of Russia's defense apparatus.

What this means for clients

Given that Europe's support for Ukraine in its war with Russia shows no sign of easing and the conflict will likely continue for some time, we should expect Putin to continue his hybrid warfare campaign. Western military support for Ukraine clearly remains a thorn in Putin's side, and he appears determined to make the West pay a price for backing Kyiv.

Against that backdrop, then, what should clients do to counter this rapidly evolving threat? Here are several suggestions:

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While Russia's hybrid warfare threat is top of mind, companies shouldn't assume those tactics will remain confined to Russia. I anticipate that Russia's hybrid operations are highly likely to encourage other state and non-state actors to develop and deploy similar capabilities, increasing the global threat to businesses. Indeed, there are already signs that the Iranian government is mirroring Russia's approach and increasingly recruiting criminal elements online in various countries to carry out hybrid attacks.
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Consider the evolution of drone warfare. Fifteen years ago, only a handful of nation-states had that capability. Today, dozens of countries and several non-state actors use armed drones routinely. I anticipate that hybrid warfare operations will, unfortunately, follow a similar path.
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In the near term, companies in the defense industry and those directly supporting Ukraine's war effort will likely sit at the top of Russia's target list. These firms should act now to protect their employees, especially senior, high-profile executives. They should formulate plans for at-risk areas to conceal and, where possible, strengthen their physical infrastructure, maintain off-site and IT redundancies, and protect vulnerable parts of their supply chains.

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On the cyber front, these companies should prioritize protecting employee identities above all else. They should enforce privileged-access management, just-in-time access, and continuous authentication. They should also treat third-party suppliers as potential attack surfaces, protect the company's most critical assets separately, and consider air-gapping sensitive data.

As Putin's frustration with the war in Ukraine grows, I'd expect his willingness to target corporate leaders abroad to increase as well.

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Business leaders in potentially affected industries should therefore direct their teams to track the latest threat and intelligence reporting and remain in especially close contact with local police and intelligence services responsible for monitoring threats.

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As part of this effort, I would also recommend tapping internal and external security experts to conduct periodic reviews of company vulnerabilities and ensure that leadership receives the results in routine briefings.

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Although the issue may seem mundane, business leaders should carefully review existing contracts and insurance policies to confirm the scope of coverage in the event of a crippling hybrid attack. During COVID, I vividly recall many parts of the defense industry being caught off guard because government contracts lacked equitable adjustment clauses for inflation that tripled because of the pandemic. Companies should prepare now to avoid a similar unpleasant surprise.

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The space sector illustrates this point. Press reports indicate that a Russian satellite last week moved threateningly close to a US commercial radar satellite that provides imagery to the Ukrainian military. Is it clear whether the US satellite provider would be compensated if a Russian hybrid operation destroyed its satellite? Similarly, what if a commercial satellite provider to the US military were destroyed in a Russian of Chinese hostile action? Would those providers be indemnified? I'm not confident of the answer in either case, but companies should determine in advance whether they would be indemnified rather than wait until after an attack.

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Finally, given the public debate over data centers and their importance to global corporations, I fully expect they will become attractive targets for future hybrid attacks by both state and non-state actors. Companies should make early and effective security planning a key factor in evaluating future data center development and construction decisions.

Ultimately, it's clear that hybrid warfare will almost certainly extend beyond governments alone and become a threat that both governments and business leaders will have to confront soon and for the foreseeable future.

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